



The One After The Superbowl

An English Vocabulary & Reading Journey

Master essential English
phrases through the biggest
sitcom episode of the 1990s.

A RECORD-BREAKING PHENOMENON

Aired on January 28, 1996, immediately following Super Bowl XXX, this special double-length episode made television history. It was designed to attract massive advertising revenue by bringing in top Hollywood talent.

52.9 Million: Total viewers
(most-watched in series history)



\$600,000: Cost for a
30-second commercial



1: Emmy Award
won for directing

VOCAB FLASHCARD

- **Broadcast (n/v):** A television or radio program.
- **Record-breaking (adj):** Surpassing all previous achievements.
- **Guest star (n):** A famous actor appearing temporarily in a show.
- **Sitcom (n):** A "situation comedy" television series.

The Cinematic 90s Sitcom Study Guide

Plot A: The Hollywood Reunion

Ross travels to the San Diego Zoo to visit his former pet monkey, Marcel. An administrator claims Marcel died, but a janitor reveals the truth: Marcel was kidnapped and forced into show business. Ross travels back to New York, where Marcel is starring in a major Hollywood movie.

VOCAB BOX (The Study Guide)

- **Reunion (n):** Coming together again after being separated.
- **Administrator (n):** A person who manages an organization.
- **Kidnapped (v):** Taken away illegally by force.
- **Show business (n):** The entertainment industry (movies, theater, TV).





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Plot B: The Date and the Trap

Summary Panel

Chandler meets Susie, a childhood classmate. In 4th grade, Chandler pulled a cruel prank on her. Now, Susie acts extremely interested in him.

They go on a date, and they make out in a restaurant bathroom. But it is a trap—Susie steals his clothes as an act of revenge, leaving him in terrible embarrassment.

Vocab Box (The Study Guide)

Prank (n): A trick played on someone as a joke.

Make out (v, informal): To kiss passionately.

Revenge (n): Action taken to hurt someone because they hurt you.

Embarrassment (n): A feeling of shame, self-consciousness, or awkwardness.



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Plot C: The Best Friend Rivalry

[Summary Panel]

Monica and Rachel both meet a famous action star on the movie set. Monica is smitten but too shy to speak to him. Rachel talks to him, but accidentally takes the date for herself. This creates fierce tension and a bitter rivalry. They fight until he suggests a threesome, at which point both women dump him.

[Vocab Box (The Study Guide)]

Smitten (adj): Strongly attracted to someone.

Tension (n): Mental or emotional strain; bad feelings between people.

Rivalry (n): Competition for the same objective or superiority.

Threesome (n): A romantic encounter involving three people.

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Plot D: The Extras

[Vocab Box (The Study Guide)]

Audition (n): An interview for a role as an actor or musician.

Overacting (v): Performing a role in an exaggerated, unnatural way.

Stalker (n): A person who obsessively harasses or follows someone.

[Summary Panel]

Joey tries desperately to get an audition for the movie. He finally lands a tiny role as a dying plague victim, but loses his only line due to severe overacting. Meanwhile, he goes on a date with a woman who turns out to be a stalker—she believes Joey is actually the fictional doctor he plays on a soap opera.

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The Character Motivation Matrix

Character	The Goal	The Outcome	Key Vocabulary
Ross	Find his old pet monkey	Spends the day in NY with him	Reunion, Kidnapped
Chandler	Date his attractive childhood friend	Tricked and left without clothes	Prank, Revenge, Embarrassment
Monica & Rachel	Date the same famous action star	They fight, then both reject him	Smitten, Rivalry, Tension
Joey	Get a role in the new movie	Hired, but fails at performing	Audition, Overacting

English in Action: Idioms & Phrasal Verbs

Panel 1: "Keep your panties on."

GREAT DOUBLE
MEANING!

Context: Chandler is trapped in the bathroom wearing only women's underwear. He asks for milk, and a friend replies, "Keep your panties on."

Meaning: A slang expression meaning "calm down" or "be patient." (Here, it is used as a double-meaning joke because Chandler is literally wearing them).

Panel 2: "Hamming it up."

Context: Joey is playing a dying plague victim, but won't stop hamming up the scene by moaning and moving too much.

Meaning: To overact; to perform in an exaggerated, theatrical way to get attention.

Comprehension Check: True or False?

1. True or False: Ross found his monkey, Marcel, living safely at the San Diego Zoo.
(False: He found him in New York working in show business).
2. True or False: Susie stole Chandler's clothes as an act of revenge for a childhood prank.
(True).
3. True or False: Monica and Rachel's rivalry ended because the famous actor chose to date Drew Barrymore instead. (False: They dumped him after he suggested a threesome).
4. True or False: Joey lost his single movie line because he was overacting.
(True).

Think & Discuss

Practice using the vocabulary from this lesson by answering these questions out loud or in writing:

1. Explain why Susie's actions against Chandler are considered revenge. Do you think her reaction was justified?
2. Describe the tension between Monica and Rachel. How does a romantic interest often test a friendship?
3. If you were a guest star on a 1990s sitcom, what kind of character would you want to play?

Great job! Review the Character Matrix anytime to refresh your memory.